Path to a Full App

How to protect your code, and what Pepper Planner still needs to become a real iPhone and web app.

Date	October 12, 2026
Bottom line	The app does what it should. Going public needs about **15–20 hours** of work for a real web app and about **40–60 more** for the App Store, plus **$99/year** paid by a parent. **None of it is needed for the competition.**
How this was checked	Apple's App Review Guidelines (updated June 8, 2026), the official 2026 CAC rules PDF, and the Supabase, Expo and GitHub docs. Sources are on the last page.

For October 26 (noon EDT): the official rules ask for a public 1–3 minute demo video and written answers. Judges "have the right to request access to the App and source code" if they want to check it. They don't require the code to be public, published, or on the App Store. Spend the next two weeks on your own feature, the video and your AI disclosure. Start this list in November.

1. Protecting your code

Done: the license is now "All rights reserved," so copying your code is no longer allowed. It also fixes a problem with the CAC rule that "no other party should have any rights or interest in the app": the old license named Expo as the owner.

Still true: because the repo is public, people can still *read* it. To hide it, make it private. The catch: on GitHub's free plan, a private repo can't host GitHub Pages, so your live link would stop working.

Recommended: get GitHub Pro free with the GitHub Student Developer Pack, then make the repo private. GitHub Pro can host Pages from a private repo, so your link keeps working.

1. Go to `education.github.com/pack` and apply. It's open to high-school students 13+ with a school email or a photo of a school ID. Approval can take a few days.
2. Once Pro is active, go to the repo's **Settings → General → Danger Zone → Change visibility → Private**.
3. Open `ashih-10.github.io/Pepper/` to make sure it still loads. The website stays public, which is fine because it's the demo.
4. If a judge asks for the code, add them as a collaborator (**Settings → Collaborators**) or send a zip.

If approval doesn't come through before the deadline, staying public is fine: the license already protects you. Two limits: anyone who downloaded the code before can't be undone, and any website's code can be downloaded from the browser. That copy is compressed, though, and leaves out the database rules, AI functions and tests.

2. Where the app stands today

Works today	Missing for real users
Accounts (email, Google), onboarding, classes	"Forgot password," and a real email service so confirmation and reset emails reach students
Tasks, recurring tasks, the pepper formula, milk check-off	A "Delete my account" button
Groups, join codes, live sync, activity feed	Report / block / word filter for shared task titles
AI photo-to-task and daily game plan	A consent screen before sending photos and tasks to Anthropic
Local pepper alerts on the phone	Server push, so a classmate's change alerts you even when the app is closed
Security tested over 3 rounds; demo link live	Privacy policy and terms; Sign in with Apple; testing on a real iPhone

3. LEVEL 1 A real web app for real students

About 15–20 hours and $0–15. This puts a working app at your own web address so classmates can actually use it.

Step	Why	Effort	Cost
Create the Supabase project (Setup Guide steps 2–6)	The real backend. Free projects **pause after 7 days with no activity**, which is fine for testing. Upgrade to Pro when real students depend on it.	1–2 hrs	$0 → $25/mo
Connect an email provider (Resend)	Supabase's built-in email **only reaches people on your Supabase team**, 2 per hour, and isn't meant for real users. Without a provider, students never get their sign-up or reset emails.	1 hr	$0
Turn email confirmation on + add a CAPTCHA to sign-up	Closes the last weakness from the security review: unlimited free fake accounts.	2 hrs	$0
"Forgot password" flow	Without it, a student who forgets their password is locked out for good.	3–4 hrs	$0
"Delete my account" button	Removes the account, tasks, memberships and shared items. Apple requires it, and it's the right call for teen users' data.	4–8 hrs	$0
Privacy policy + terms page	Must name Supabase, Google and Anthropic, say what classmates can see, and explain deletion. Have a parent or teacher review it.	3–5 hrs	$0
AI consent screen	Before the first photo or game plan: "This is sent to Anthropic to process. Allow?" Apple requires this as of Nov 2025.	2–4 hrs	$0
Host on Vercel with your own domain	Gives the real app its own address. The shared GitHub Pages address could expose sign-in sessions to your other Pages sites.	1 hr	~$12/yr

4. LEVEL 2 The iPhone App Store

About 40–60 hours on top of Level 1, plus $99/year. Every item below comes from Apple's current guidelines.

Step	What Apple requires	Effort
Developer account	$99/year. You must be 18 or older, so **a parent enrolls** with their Apple account and shares it with you, and their name shows as the seller.	1 hr + wait

First iPhone build with EAS	No Mac needed. The free plan gives 15 iOS builds a month, and the queue can be slow. Uploads must use the iOS 26 SDK or newer, which EAS handles.	4–8 hrs
Test on a real iPhone (TestFlight)	Apple rejects apps that weren't "tested on-device." Pepper has never run on a real phone. TestFlight takes up to 100 testers on your team, and up to 10,000 more through a public link after a quick beta review.	3–6 hrs
Sign in with Apple	Rule 4.8: an app offering Google sign-in must also offer a privacy-focused option. Sign in with Apple is the standard answer. The alternative is dropping Google on iPhone.	4–8 hrs
Report, block and a word filter	Rule 1.2: classmates see each other's task titles and activity, which counts as user-generated content. You'd also need a contact email, and you're expected to remove bad content.	8–16 hrs
Account deletion, AI consent, privacy policy	Rules 5.1.1(v), 5.1.2(i) and 5.1.1(i). These are the Level 1 items, already done.	—
Age rating + teen age checks	Set the rating to 13+ to match the app. Texas, Utah and Louisiana now require age checks for teen accounts, using Apple's Declared Age Range tool. Have a parent or teacher check the legal side.	5–10 hrs
Server push notifications	Not required by Apple, but it's what makes groups feel live. It uses Expo's free push service: store each phone's push token, then send from a server function when a deadline changes.	8–12 hrs
App Privacy label + review	Declare email, name, user ID and task text, none of it used for tracking. Give reviewers a demo account and keep the backend on. Most reviews finish within 48 hours.	2–3 hrs

5. LEVEL 3 Polish, later

- **Your own name and icon.** This also removes the last piece of Expo's template.
- **Web push alerts.** On iPhone these only work after "Add to Home Screen," and developers report subscriptions randomly stopping. Treat it as a bonus, not a core feature.
- **Google Classroom / Canvas import**, offline mode, an accessibility pass, dark mode.
- **Android / Google Play.** The same code builds for Android; Google charges a one-time developer fee.

6. What it costs

Item	Cost
GitHub Student Developer Pack (includes Pro)	$0

Supabase	$0 while testing; $25/month once real students rely on it
Resend email, Vercel hosting, Expo builds (free plans)	$0
Your own domain	~$12/year
Claude API	Pay per use; keep the Console spend cap (~$10)
Apple Developer Program (parent enrolls)	$99/year

7. My recommendation

> **Don't build the App Store version yet.** It's 40–60 hours plus $99 a year, during basketball season, before anyone has used the app for real. Ship Level 1 first and get 10–20 classmates using it for a month. If they keep opening it, that's your signal to do Level 2, with a parent enrolling. Finding out whether people want something before spending time and money on it is the same habit that matters in markets.

1. **Now (5 minutes):** apply for the GitHub Student Developer Pack.
2. **Before Oct 26:** your own feature (practice quiet hours), the demo video and the AI disclosure. Nothing from this PDF.
3. **November** (about an hour a day around practice): Level 1, over 2–3 weeks.
4. **Winter or spring:** Level 2, only if classmates are really using it. This year's rules allow a "2.0 version" where only the new code is judged. If next year's rules keep that, the App Store version could be your 2027 entry.

Sources

Apple App Review Guidelines (updated June 8, 2026): developer.apple.com/app-store/review/guidelines/ — rules 1.2, 2.1, 4.8, 5.1.1, 5.1.2
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